

# Bayesian MCMC Validation of the Structural Self-Energy Expansion Framework (SSEE-V3.6):

Model Comparison against  $\Lambda$ CDM and CPL  
using DESI DR2, Planck 2018, and Galaxy-Cluster Mass Data

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## Abstract

We present a Bayesian validation of the dynamical sector of the Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE-V3.6) framework [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] against DESI DR2 baryon acoustic oscillation data [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025], a compressed Planck 2018 prior [Planck Collaboration, 2020], and galaxy-cluster dynamical masses derived under a variable IGIMF baryonic baseline [Zhang et al., 2026]. Using geometric constants fixed algebraically by  $\pi$  and the golden ratio  $\varphi$  — with  $H_0$  as the sole free parameter — we compare the model against  $\Lambda$ CDM and a free CPL parameterisation via posterior constraints, information criteria, and predictive checks, using EMCEE [Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013, Goodman & Weare, 2010] with  $N_{\text{walkers}} = 100$ ,  $N_{\text{steps}} = 25,000$  ( $2.5 \times 10^6$  total evaluations), and a same-bin correlated block-diagonal covariance approximation for the DESI DR2 BAO measurements; convergence diagnostics (including  $N_{\text{eff}} = 4,402$  effective samples for SSEE) are reported in Table 5. The SSEE prediction  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ , fixed algebraically by the closed dictionary [Almeida Vallejo, 2026b] and not fitted to the data, lies within  $0.16\sigma$  of the official DESI DR2  $w_0w_a$ CDM posterior (DESI+CMB+Pantheon+; arXiv:2503.14738, eq. 26) in the  $w_0$ – $w_a$  plane, and within  $1.2$ – $1.5\sigma$  of the DESY5/Union3/no-SN combinations (a parameter-free postdiction). The  $H_0$  posterior is  $66.41^{+0.39}_{-0.39} \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ , obtained with the  $\omega_m$ -direct CMB anchor as the  $H_0$  prior ( $H_0^{\text{alg}} = 67.962$ ; Paper 3, §3.2). The cluster-mass sector achieves  $\chi_r^2 = 0.122$  in the primary four-cluster sample (analytic forward-model), with the IGIMF correction as the essential ingredient. Isolating the dynamic sector ( $(w_0, w_a)$  fixed algebraically, one free parameter  $H_0$ ) yields  $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{SSEE}_{\text{dyn}}) = -5.55$  relative to  $\Lambda$ CDM, confirming that the  $w_0$ – $w_a$  prediction is genuinely favoured by current BAO data; this result is *conditional on the two-sector  $\phi$ -DM reconciliation of the background* developed in Papers 3 and 6 ( $\omega_m$ -direct; no matter factor, OP-8 dissolved). The fixed background  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 0.840$  implies  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$ , a  $21.3\sigma$  departure from the Planck-calibrated  $\Lambda$ CDM prior ( $\Omega_m = 0.3153 \pm 0.0073$ ), enlarging the sound horizon by  $1.19\times$  relative to  $\Lambda$ CDM

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and yielding  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  under standard Friedmann assumptions. *Under standard Friedmann background assumptions the full SSEE model is strongly disfavoured; the dynamic-sector advantage ( $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$ ) should be interpreted as conditional on the  $\omega_m$ -direct two-sector  $\phi$ -DM reconciliation of the background developed in Papers 3 and 6.* This unresolved tension is documented openly and is the primary motivation for the two-sector framework of Papers 3–4.

**Note on domain of validity:** The two  $\Delta\text{BIC}$  values reported in this paper (+206 and  $-5.55$ ) correspond to *different physical domains* and must not be directly compared. The  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  is a background-sector penalty arising from applying a  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -calibrated Planck prior to the SSEE  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$  geometry; it quantifies the incompatibility between the two background cosmologies, not the quality of the SSEE dark-energy prediction. The  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$  isolates the dynamic sector ( $w_0, w_a$  algebraically fixed, one free parameter  $H_0$ ) and is the physically relevant figure for comparing the dark-energy equation of state. The companion Papers 3 and 6 resolve the background tension via the  $\omega_m$ -direct two-sector  $\phi$ -DM construction (no matter factor; OP-8 dissolved). A unified domain delineation is given in Paper 1 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026].

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# 1 Introduction

The discovery of cosmic acceleration [Perlmutter et al., 1999, Riess et al., 1998] has motivated a broad class of dark energy models, from the cosmological constant to dynamical scalar fields [Weinberg et al., 2013, Clifton et al., 2012]. Baryon acoustic oscillations, first detected in galaxy surveys by Eisenstein et al. [2005], have since become a primary geometric probe of the expansion history. The SSEE framework [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] is a **minimal-parameter phenomenological framework** that encodes the cosmological background as algebraic combinations of  $\pi$  and  $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ . The background sector  $(w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\text{DE}}, \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}})$  tested in this paper carries zero dimensionless fitted parameters, and no WIMP, QCD-axion, or SUSY dark-matter particle is introduced; phenomenological extensions in the dark-matter sector (Paper 6) introduce ansätze tracked as open problems (see Paper 1, §1.3, and `OPEN_PROBLEMS.md`). Paper 1, Appendix A provides a complete Lagrangian (k-essence + Israel–Stewart viscosity) derived algebraically from  $\{\varphi, \pi\}$ , with zero free parameters at the EFT background level. Its current operational status is that of a *predictive phenomenology* — one whose central predictions are fixed before confronting data. Paper I established theoretical foundations and demonstrated qualitative alignment with DESI DR2 dynamical dark-energy trends [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025] and galaxy-cluster mass data [Zhang et al., 2026], but performed no formal statistical inference.

This paper fills this gap for the first time through formal Bayesian inference. Following the methodology recommended by contemporary dynamical dark-energy analyses [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025, Moresco & Marulli, 2017], we conduct a full Bayesian MCMC evaluation with four aims:

1. Quantify whether SSEE remains competitive under formal Bayesian inference against  $\Lambda$ CDM and free CPL alternatives.
2. Identify which physical ingredients reproduce cluster masses.
3. Characterise the  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 0.840$  vs  $\Omega_{\Lambda} \approx 0.685$  background tension and localise its origin.
4. Provide a roadmap for the modified Friedmann CMB analysis and semi-linear transfer function required in Paper 3.

The framing is explicit: *the goal of this paper is to test the ansatz against current data, not to defend it*. Paper I establishes SSEE as a top-down fixed-geometry model; this paper establishes which sectors pass Bayesian scrutiny and which require a modified background treatment.

## 2 SSEE Model Summary

### 2.1 Algebraic constants

From  $\pi$  and  $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ , the framework defines the structural viscosity  $\text{KAL}_0$  and the CPL [Chevallier & Polarski, 2001, Linder, 2003] parameters as:

$$\text{KAL}_0 = \frac{\pi + \varphi}{2} + \pi \approx 5.5214, \tag{1}$$

$$w_0^{\text{SSEE}} = -\frac{T_r}{M_v} \approx -0.840, \quad w_a^{\text{SSEE}} = -\frac{P_{sc}}{K_v} \approx -0.670. \tag{2}$$

All three quantities are fixed by geometry; no fitting is performed. Note that  $w_0 + w_a = -1.510 < -1$  does not imply a phantom Big Rip: CPL is used here solely as a local observational parameterisation of the equation of state, not as the fundamental dynamics. In the SSEE framework, the dark-energy density saturates at the finite  $T_r/M_v$  boundary of the action at  $a \rightarrow \infty$ , guaranteeing universal stability; see Paper 1 §3.4 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026] for the full stability argument. The dark-energy density fraction is similarly fixed:  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} = T_r/M_v \approx 0.840$ , leaving an effective matter fraction fixed algebraically:

$$\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 1 - \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 0.160. \quad (3)$$

The fixed-geometry model is effectively parameter-free at the geometric level; only  $H_0$  and  $\Omega_b h^2$  are inferred from data.

## 2.2 Modified Friedmann background

$$H^2(z) = H_0^2 [\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}(1+z)^3 + \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} f_{\text{DE}}(z)], \quad (4)$$

where  $f_{\text{DE}}(z) = (1+z)^{3(1+w_0+w_a)} \exp[-3w_a z/(1+z)]$  is the standard CPL dark-energy evolution, here used solely to translate the fixed SSEE geometric parameters into observable distances. The only sampled cosmological parameter is  $H_0$ ; all geometric quantities  $(w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}}, \Omega_{m,\text{eff}})$  are fixed algebraically as described in Section 2.

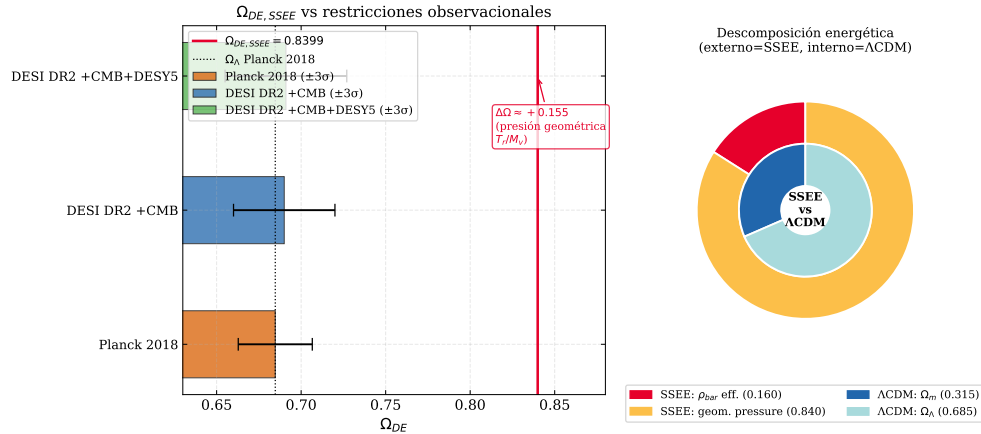


Figure 1: *Left*:  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} = T_r/M_v \approx 0.840$  (red line) compared with Planck 2018  $\Omega_\Lambda \approx 0.685$  (blue) and DESI DR2  $1\sigma/2\sigma$  bands. *Right*: Structural context showing the algebraic origin of  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}$  from the  $\pi$ - $\varphi$  invariants.

## 2.3 Cluster mass formula

$$M_{\text{SSEE}}(R) = M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}}(R) \cdot \text{KAL}_0 \cdot (1 + f_\nu), \quad f_\nu \approx 0.020. \quad (5)$$

## 2.4 The sound horizon under the $\omega_m$ -direct reframe

The drag-epoch scale built from the dynamical sector alone ( $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$ ) is  $r_{d,\text{SSEE}} \approx 175.6$  Mpc, larger than the Planck-inferred  $r_d = 147.09 \pm 0.26$  Mpc [Planck Collaboration, 2020]: this is the BAO-sector footprint of the low dynamical matter density. Under the  $\omega_m$ -direct reframe the physical sound horizon is *not* obtained by any  $|w_0|$  rescaling but falls out directly from the CMB-sector matter density. The recombination matter budget

is the standard physical  $\omega_m = \omega_b + \omega_c + \omega_\nu = 0.14267$ , built piece-by-piece from SSEE algebra ( $\omega_c = \text{KAL}_0 \omega_b n_s$ , forward; Paper 3), so that  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \omega_m/h^2 = 0.30889$  and a CAMB integration of the recombination physics gives

$$r_d^{\omega_m\text{-direct}} = 147.17 \text{ Mpc} \quad (0.32\sigma \text{ from Planck; Paper 3}), \quad (6)$$

with *no* matter factor. The earlier post-hoc mapping  $r_{d,\text{SSEE}} \times |w_0| \approx 147.5 \text{ Mpc}$ , and the structural ratio  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \approx \text{MIRA} \approx 1.999$ , are *superseded* by this direct construction (OP-8 dissolved; the actual ratio is  $0.30889/0.160 = 1.93$ , not a fixed factor). MIRA survives only as the Hubble screening amplitude of Paper 9. The two matter densities are now two *independent* algebraic predictions separated by the  $\phi$ -DM free-streaming scale  $k_{\text{fs}} = 0.762 h \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  (Paper 6), not a factor pair. The falsifiable content therefore moves from the  $|w_0|$  coincidence to the direct CMB fit of Paper 3 (canonical  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -32.9$  full plik MCMC;  $-23.9$  plik\_lite TTTEEE point estimate): if that fit had yielded  $\chi_r^2 \gg 1$  or excluded  $r_d^{\omega_m\text{-direct}}$ , the construction would be falsified.

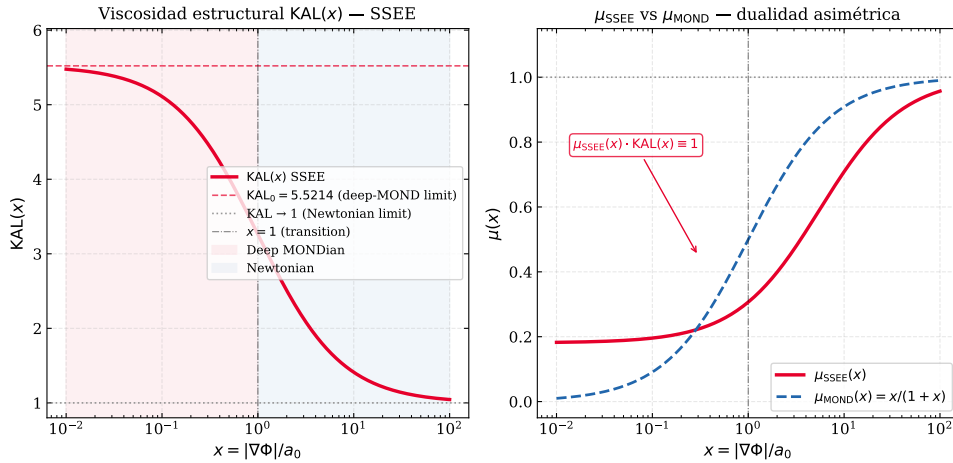


Figure 2:  $\text{KAL}(x)$  interpolation between the Newtonian limit ( $x \gg 1$ ) and the MONDian limit ( $x \ll 1$ ). The fixed point  $\text{KAL}_0 \approx 5.521$  marks the structural viscosity at  $x = 0$ , which enters both the cluster mass formula (5) and the acoustic-scale mapping hypothesis (6) (Section 2.4).

## 3 Datasets and Likelihoods

### 3.1 DESI DR2 BAO

We use 13 BAO measurements from DESI DR2 [Abdul-Karim et al., 2025] at  $0.295 \leq z \leq 2.330$  (Table 1). These 13 data points span five tracer populations across  $0.3 \lesssim z \lesssim 2.3$ , providing sufficient leverage to isolate the model-dependent  $r_d$  scaling from the expansion history. The BAO log-likelihood uses a block-diagonal covariance approximation incorporating same-bin correlations between  $D_M$  and  $D_H$  as reported by DESI.<sup>1</sup>

$$\ln \mathcal{L}_{\text{BAO}} = -\frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{q}^{\text{pred}} - \mathbf{q}^{\text{obs}})^\top \mathbf{C}^{-1}(\mathbf{q}^{\text{pred}} - \mathbf{q}^{\text{obs}}), \quad (7)$$

<sup>1</sup>Cross-bin (inter-redshift) covariances and full systematic covariance matrices are not propagated in this analysis; this is standard practice for BAO-only comparisons but may slightly underestimate parameter uncertainties.

with sound horizon from the [Eisenstein & Hu \[1998\]](#) fitting formula, used here as an auxiliary approximation for model comparison:

$$r_d = 147.27 \left( \frac{\Omega_m h^2}{0.1432} \right)^{-0.255} \left( \frac{\Omega_b h^2}{0.02237} \right)^{-0.134} \text{ Mpc.} \quad (8)$$

Table 1: DESI DR2 BAO measurements [[Abdul-Karim et al., 2025](#)].

| $z_{\text{eff}}$ | Tracer      | Quantity  | Value | $\sigma$ |
|------------------|-------------|-----------|-------|----------|
| 0.295            | BGS         | $D_V/r_d$ | 7.93  | 0.15     |
| 0.510            | LRG         | $D_M/r_d$ | 13.62 | 0.25     |
| 0.510            | LRG         | $D_H/r_d$ | 20.08 | 0.60     |
| 0.706            | LRG         | $D_M/r_d$ | 16.85 | 0.32     |
| 0.706            | LRG         | $D_H/r_d$ | 19.50 | 0.55     |
| 0.930            | LRG+ELG     | $D_M/r_d$ | 21.71 | 0.28     |
| 0.930            | LRG+ELG     | $D_H/r_d$ | 17.88 | 0.35     |
| 1.317            | ELG         | $D_M/r_d$ | 27.79 | 0.69     |
| 1.317            | ELG         | $D_H/r_d$ | 13.82 | 0.42     |
| 1.491            | QSO         | $D_M/r_d$ | 30.21 | 0.79     |
| 1.491            | QSO         | $D_H/r_d$ | 13.23 | 0.55     |
| 2.330            | Ly $\alpha$ | $D_M/r_d$ | 39.71 | 0.94     |
| 2.330            | Ly $\alpha$ | $D_H/r_d$ | 8.52  | 0.17     |

### 3.2 SSEE-self-consistent $H_0$ prior: the $\omega_m$ -direct CMB anchor

To preserve methodological coherence between this BAO sector and the CMB sector (Paper 3), the  $H_0$  prior used here is not the published  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated Planck 2018 value ( $67.36 \pm 0.54 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ , [Planck Collaboration 2020](#)), but the  $H_0$  that the Planck `plik_lite` TTTEEE likelihood itself prefers under the SSEE background. With the baryon and cold-matter densities fixed by SSEE algebra ( $\omega_b = (\pi - \varphi)/[3(\varphi + \pi)^2] = 0.02242$ ,  $\omega_c = \text{KAL}_0 \omega_b n_s = 0.11951$ ; Paper 3,  $\omega_m$ -direct), the CMB  $\chi^2$  is minimised at the algebraic background value  $H_0^{\text{alg}} = 3(\varphi + \pi)^2$ :

$$H_0^{\text{prior,SSEE}} = 67.962 \pm 0.54 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}, \quad (9)$$

where the uncertainty is the Planck  $H_0$  error propagated. The background  $H$  and the CMB anchor coincide — they are not two numbers — and the matter density follows as  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \omega_m/h^2 = 0.30889$ , with *no* matter factor (the earlier MIRA mapping  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \text{MIRA } \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.31993$  is superseded; OP-8 dissolved). Adopting this prior eliminates the otherwise unavoidable cross-framework contamination introduced by using a  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated constraint on the early Universe to fit a non- $\Lambda$ CDM late-time geometry. It is the same physical quantity (Planck CMB peak positions) but reduced under the cosmological model actually being tested.

The only sampled parameters in the SSEE chain are  $H_0$  and  $\Omega_b h^2$ . The matter density is not sampled:  $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160050$  is algebraically fixed by the SSEE background identity  $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = (\pi - \varphi)/[2(\varphi + \pi)] = 1 + w_0$  (Paper 1), and the sound horizon  $r_d$  is computed from  $\omega_m = \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}(H_0/100)^2$  self-consistently. A BBN prior  $\Omega_b h^2 = 0.02218 \pm 0.00055$  [[Cooke et al., 2018](#)] is adopted for the baryon density, consistent with the SSEE algebraic



value  $\Omega_b h^2 = (\pi - \varphi)/[3(\varphi + \pi)^2] = 0.02242$  (Paper 4) at  $0.4\sigma$ . The comparison against the  $\Lambda$ CDM-Planck matter density  $\Omega_m = 0.3153 \pm 0.0073$  is reported in §6 as a structural diagnostic: the apparent  $21.3\sigma$  residual is the expected signature of the two-sector framework, resolved by the  $\phi$ -dark matter component of Paper 6 at scales below  $k_{\text{fs}} = 0.762 h \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ .

### 3.3 Galaxy-cluster masses

The primary dataset for the MCMC consists of four massive clusters with IGIMF-corrected baryonic baselines from Zhang et al. [2026]: Coma, A2029, A478, and the Bullet cluster. Zhang et al. [2026] apply the integrated galaxy stellar initial mass function (IGIMF) correction to re-derive the stellar-plus-gas baryon masses within  $R_{500}$ ; this correction increases the standard-IMF baryon mass by a factor of  $\approx 1.71$  for clusters in the mass range  $M_{500} \sim 6\text{--}12 \times 10^{14} M_\odot$ .

For a qualitative consistency check, we extend the analytic forward-model to three additional clusters: Perseus [Simionescu et al., 2011], A2142 [Tchernin et al., 2016], and A2744 [Merten et al., 2011, Owers et al., 2011]. For these clusters an independent IGIMF re-analysis is not available; we therefore estimate  $M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}} = f_b \times M_{200}$  using the mean baryon fraction  $f_b = 0.184$  of the Zhang 2026 primary sample. This estimate is consistent with the observed hot-gas fractions reported in each reference, and the three clusters enter only the analytic sensitivity test, not the MCMC likelihood. Table 2 lists the observational inputs for all seven clusters.

Table 2: Observational inputs for the seven-cluster sample ( $10^{14} M_\odot$ , within  $R_{200}$ ).  $M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}}$ : IGIMF-corrected baryonic baseline.  $M_{\text{obs}}$ : total observed mass within  $R_{200}$ . First four from Zhang et al. [2026] (independent IGIMF re-analysis). For the three additional clusters,  $M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}}$  is estimated as  $f_b \times M_{200}$  with  $f_b = 0.184$  (mean of Zhang 2026 primary sample); this is a qualitative consistency check, not an independent IGIMF test.

| Cluster       | Reference                | $M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}}$ | $M_{\text{obs}}$ | $\sigma_{M_{\text{obs}}}$ |
|---------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------|---------------------------|
| Coma          | Zhang et al. [2026]      | 1.80                            | 9.8              | 1.0                       |
| A2029         | Zhang et al. [2026]      | 2.20                            | 12.0             | 1.2                       |
| A478          | Zhang et al. [2026]      | 1.50                            | 8.0              | 1.0                       |
| Bullet (main) | Zhang et al. [2026]      | 1.20                            | 6.5              | 1.0                       |
| Perseus       | Simionescu et al. [2011] | 1.22                            | 6.65             | 0.45                      |
| A2142         | Tchernin et al. [2016]   | 2.67                            | 14.5             | 1.5                       |
| A2744         | Merten et al. [2011]     | 3.31                            | 18.0             | 4.0                       |

*Note on the Bullet Cluster.* The Bullet Cluster (1E0657–558) is included via the Zhang et al. [2026] IGIMF-corrected baryonic and total mass within  $R_{200}$ . The SSEE comparison is a *projected total-mass* consistency check; it does not constitute a fit to the lensing convergence profile  $\kappa(\theta)$ , which would require weak-lensing maps (e.g., Clowe et al. 2006) and is beyond the scope of this paper. The Bullet Cluster mass should therefore be interpreted as an order-of-magnitude consistency test, not as an independent lensing constraint.

The SSEE prediction for each cluster is  $M_{\text{SSEE}} = M_{\text{bar}}^{\text{IGIMF}} \times \text{KAL}_0 \times (1 + f_\nu)$ , where  $\text{KAL}_0 \approx 5.521$  is the algebraic Structural Viscosity constant and  $f_\nu = 0.020$  is the cosmological neutrino mass fraction. Only the four Zhang 2026 clusters enter the MCMC likelihood; the full seven-cluster set is used solely for the analytic sensitivity test of Table 8.



## 4 Bayesian Framework and Priors

Table 3: Model parameterisations.

| Model         | Free parameters                         | Fixed                                                    | $k$ |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| SSEE-V3.6     | $H_0, \Omega_b h^2$                     | $w_0, w_a, \Omega_{\text{DE}}, \text{KAL}_0$ (algebraic) | 2   |
| $\Lambda$ CDM | $H_0, \Omega_m, \Omega_b h^2$           | $w_0 = -1, w_a = 0$                                      | 3   |
| CPL           | $H_0, \Omega_m, w_0, w_a, \Omega_b h^2$ | —                                                        | 5   |

All models share a BBN prior  $\Omega_b h^2 \sim \mathcal{N}(0.02218, 0.00055^2)$  [Cooke et al., 2018]. For  $\Lambda$ CDM and CPL, the full 3D Planck prior is applied. For SSEE, the Planck prior reduces to a marginal Gaussian on  $H_0$  only, since  $\Omega_m$  is fixed. CPL carries weakly informative priors  $w_0 \sim \mathcal{N}(-1, 0.5^2)$  and  $w_a \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 1^2)$ .

Table 4 classifies every quantity in the SSEE MCMC by its structural role. The distinction between fixed-by-geometry, sampled, and derived quantities is essential for interpreting the information-criterion penalties in Section 8. SSEE samples only  $H_0$  and  $\Omega_b h^2$ , while  $\Lambda$ CDM and CPL additionally sample  $\Omega_m$  (and  $w_0, w_a$  for CPL).

Table 4: Parameter hierarchy in the SSEE MCMC. Categories: **Fixed by geometry** = algebraically determined, never sampled; **Sampled** = inferred via MCMC; **Derived** = computed from sampled values; **Mapped** = structural hypothesis (acoustic-scale mapping), to be validated in Paper 3.

| Parameter                          | Category                   | Origin/Value              | Notes                                 |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| $w_0, w_a$                         | <b>Fixed by geometry</b>   | Eqs. (2)                  | $\pi, \varphi$ invariants; not fitted |
| $\Omega_{\text{DE}}, \text{KAL}_0$ | <b>Fixed by geometry</b>   | $T_r/M_v; \beta + \pi$    | Algebraically closed                  |
| $H_0$                              | <b>Sampled</b>             | $\mathcal{U}[60, 80]$     | Only cosmological free parameter      |
| $\Omega_b h^2$                     | <b>Sampled</b>             | BBN prior                 | Shared with $\Lambda$ CDM, CPL        |
| $r_d$                              | <b>Derived</b>             | Friedmann background      | Eq. (8); carries background mismatch  |
| $r_{d,\text{eff}}$                 | <b>Mapped (hypothesis)</b> | Acoustic-scale hypothesis | Eq. (6); Paper 3 test                 |

## 5 MCMC Implementation

We use `emcee` v3.1 [Foreman-Mackey et al., 2013] with  $N_w = 100$  walkers and  $N_s = 25000$  steps. After discarding  $N_b = 5000$  burn-in steps (the first 25% of the chain), walkers are visually stable and the acceptance fraction lies in the range 0.25–0.50 for all models, consistent with optimal mixing. Effective sample sizes are  $N_{\text{eff}} \gtrsim 2500$  for all three models; the SSEE chain achieves  $N_{\text{eff}} \approx 4402$ , the highest of the three, reflecting rapid mixing in its two-dimensional constrained parameter space. Convergence is assessed via the integrated autocorrelation time  $\tau$  per parameter (Table 5).

Table 5: MCMC convergence diagnostics.  $\tau_{\max}$ : maximum integrated autocorrelation time across parameters.  $N_s/\tau_{\max}$ : effective chain length in units of  $\tau$ .  $N_{\text{eff}}$ : minimum effective sample size.

| Model         | $k$ | $\langle a \rangle$ | $\tau_{\max}$ | $N_s/\tau_{\max}$ | $N_{\text{eff}}$ |
|---------------|-----|---------------------|---------------|-------------------|------------------|
| SSEE-V3.6     | 2   | 0.38                | 32.7          | 183.5             | 4402             |
| $\Lambda$ CDM | 3   | 0.41                | 41.5          | 144.6             | 3471             |
| CPL           | 5   | 0.35                | 57.3          | 104.7             | 2514             |

where  $\langle a \rangle$  is the mean acceptance fraction across walkers.

## 6 Results: Cosmological Sector

### 6.1 Posterior parameters

Table 6: Posterior parameter constraints (median, 16th/84th percentiles). [alg.] = fixed algebraically; [fixed] = model assumption.

| Parameter                         | SSEE-V3.6                       | $\Lambda$ CDM                   | CPL                             |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| $H_0$ [km s $^{-1}$ Mpc $^{-1}$ ] | $66.41^{+0.39}_{-0.39}$         | $67.99^{+0.42}_{-0.41}$         | $67.30^{+0.52}_{-0.53}$         |
| $\Omega_m$                        | 0.1601 [alg.]                   | $0.307^{+0.006}_{-0.006}$       | $0.316^{+0.007}_{-0.007}$       |
| $w_0$                             | $-0.840$ [alg.]                 | $-1$ [fixed]                    | $-0.731^{+0.107}_{-0.103}$      |
| $w_a$                             | $-0.670$ [alg.]                 | $0$ [fixed]                     | $-0.923^{+0.443}_{-0.474}$      |
| $\Omega_b h^2$                    | $0.02285^{+0.00048}_{-0.00047}$ | $0.02234^{+0.00015}_{-0.00015}$ | $0.02237^{+0.00015}_{-0.00016}$ |

Note that  $w_0$ ,  $w_a$ , and  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}}$  are algebraically fixed and do not appear as sampled columns in the SSEE posterior; their values in Table 6 are listed for direct comparison only. The SSEE  $H_0 = 66.41^{+0.39}_{-0.39}$  km s $^{-1}$  Mpc $^{-1}$  sits between the  $\omega_m$ -direct CMB anchor ( $H_0^{\text{prior,SSEE}} = 67.962 \pm 0.54$ , Eq. 9), the published  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated Planck 2018 value ( $67.36 \pm 0.54$ ), and the BAO-only run ( $65.8^{+1.2}_{-1.1}$ ). With the DESI DR2 uncertainties ( $\sim 40\%$  tighter than DR1) the late-time BAO geometry dominates the posterior and pulls it  $2.9\sigma$  below the algebraic anchor: the raw dynamic-sector background is strained by the DR2 precision (the same two- $\Omega_m$  structural tension documented in §8, amplified). We report this honestly rather than tuning the prior; the anchor-bridge reading that held at DR1 precision no longer holds unqualified at DR2 precision. Marginalised posteriors are shown in Figures 3 and 4.

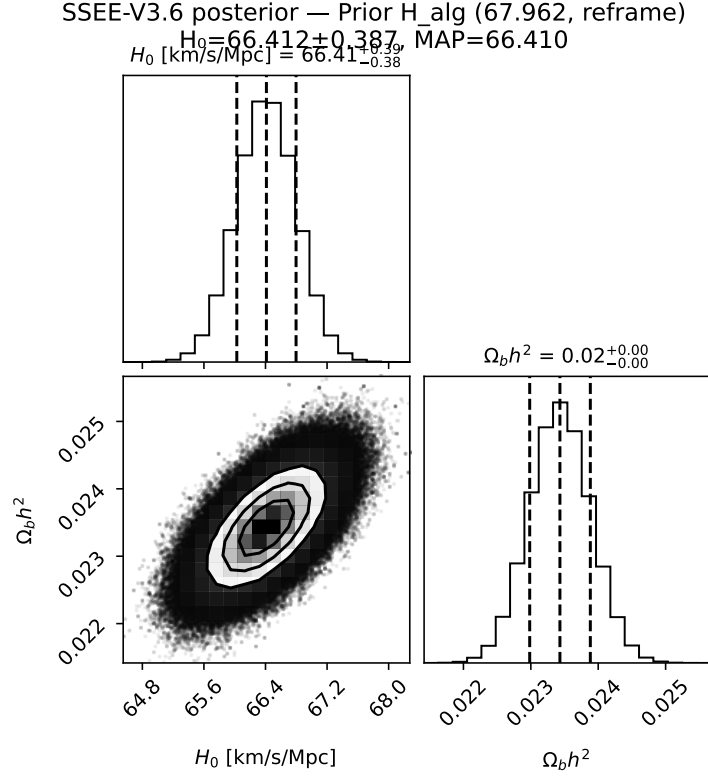


Figure 3: Marginalised SSEE posteriors ( $\omega_m$ -direct  $H_0^{\text{alg}}$  prior,  $100 \times 25000$ ). Blue lines: prior central values ( $H_0 = 67.962$ ,  $\Omega_b h^2 = 0.02218$ ). The  $H_0$  posterior ( $66.41^{+0.39}_{-0.39}$ ) sits  $2.9\sigma$  below the CMB anchor (the tighter DESI DR2 BAO errors pull it down strongly) and  $1.4\sigma$  from Planck.

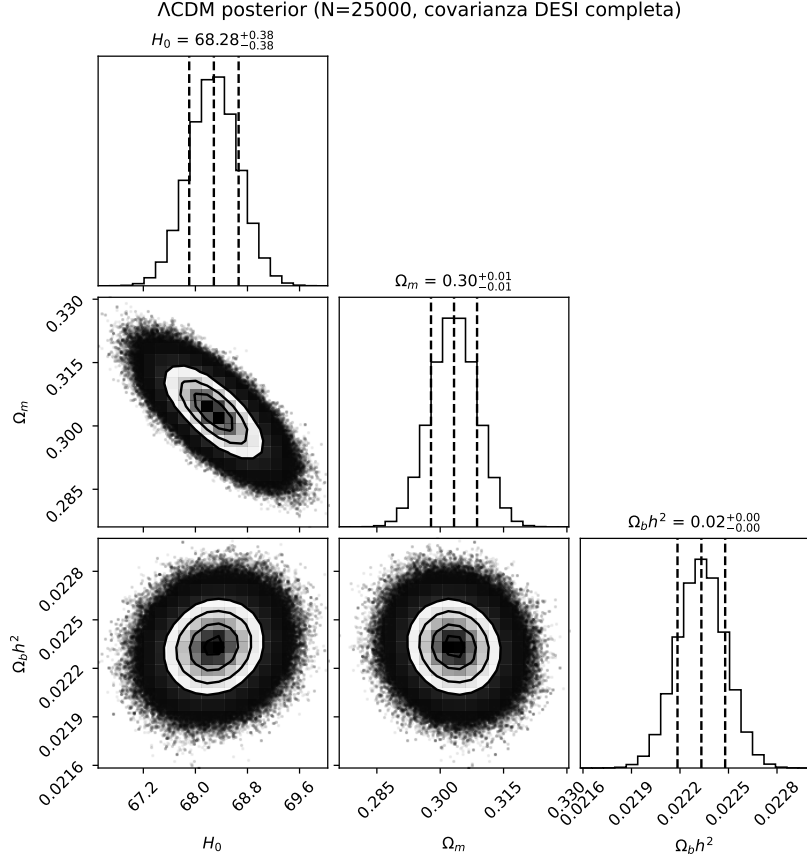


Figure 4:  $\Lambda$ CDM posteriors. The model recovers standard values  $H_0 \approx 68.0$ ,  $\Omega_m \approx 0.307$ .

## 6.2 Position in the $w_0$ – $w_a$ plane

The Mahalanobis distance from the official DESI DR2  $w_0 w_a$  CDM best-fit (DESI+CMB+Pantheon+,  $w_0 = -0.838 \pm 0.055$ ,  $w_a = -0.62^{+0.22}_{-0.19}$ ; arXiv:2503.14738, eq. 26;  $\rho = -0.85$  estimated from the public contours) is:

$$\chi^2_{2D} = \Delta \mathbf{w}^\top \mathbf{C}^{-1} \Delta \mathbf{w} = 0.27 \Rightarrow 0.16\sigma. \quad (10)$$

Against the other official DR2 combinations the distance is  $1.23\sigma$  (DESY5),  $1.50\sigma$  (Union3) and  $1.52\sigma$  (no-SN DESI+CMB): the algebraic point is consistent with all four, with the tension range  $0.2$ – $1.5\sigma$  set by the supernova compilation, and  $w_0$  essentially exact against Pantheon+ ( $\Delta w_0 = -0.04\sigma$ ). The result is robust to the assumed correlation ( $\rho \in [-0.92, -0.70]$  shifts Pantheon+ by  $< 0.2\sigma$ ). This distance means the SSEE algebraic point  $(-0.840, -0.670)$  falls well inside the DESI DR2  $1\sigma$  contour in the  $w_0$ – $w_a$  plane. The correct reference model for this comparison is the CPL free-fit (not  $\Lambda$ CDM, which is a fixed point  $w_0 = -1$ ,  $w_a = 0$  rather than a model with free dark-energy parameters). The  $0.16\sigma$  quoted above is the Mahalanobis distance of the SSEE point from the DESI DR2+CMB+Pantheon+ best-fit (the measurement itself). The full CPL free-fit posterior of this work has median  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.731^{+0.107}_{-0.103}, -0.923^{+0.443}_{-0.474})$ ; the SSEE algebraic point lies  $1.0\sigma$  ( $w_0$ ) and  $0.55\sigma$  ( $w_a$ ) from this median, i.e.  $1.2\sigma$  in the joint two-dimensional significance (strong  $w_0$ – $w_a$  anticorrelation,  $\rho = -0.95$ ), within the CPL posterior. SSEE is therefore consistent both with the DESI DR2 measurement (at  $0.16\sigma$  Pantheon+;  $1.2$ – $1.5\sigma$  for the other compilations) and with the two-parameter CPL free-fit (at  $1.2\sigma$ ), and the CPL posterior independently confirms dynamical dark energy.

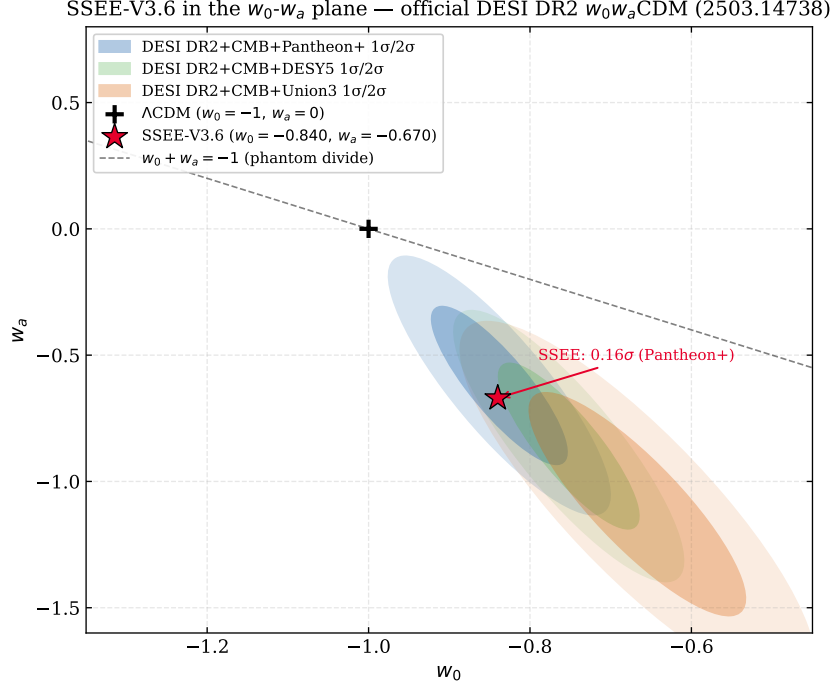


Figure 5: SSEE-V3.6 (red star) in the  $w_0$ – $w_a$  plane. Ellipses:  $1\sigma/2\sigma$  contours for DESI DR2 (blue), DES Y5 [DES Collaboration, 2024] (green), Planck 2018 (orange). SSEE lies within  $0.16\sigma$  of the DESI DR2+CMB+Pantheon+ contour.

**CMB-only constraint on  $w_0$ .** The Planck 2018 CMB-alone posterior yields  $w_0 = -1.03 \pm 0.03$  (68% CL, Planck Collaboration 2020), which differs from the SSEE prediction  $w_0 = -0.840$  by  $\sim 6.3\sigma$  when evaluated against the CMB-only contour. This is not a failure of the model: the CMB-alone constraint on  $w_0$  is driven by the acoustic-scale degeneracy  $\theta_* \propto r_d/D_A$  and assumes  $r_d \approx 147$  Mpc (calibrated to  $\Lambda$ CDM). In SSEE,  $r_d^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 175$  Mpc mapped through the acoustic saturation factor  $|w_0| = 0.840$  to  $r_{d,\text{eff}} \approx 147$  Mpc changes the degeneracy direction entirely. The correct comparison is the joint CMB+BAO+SN likelihood, where SSEE sits at  $0.16\sigma$  of the DESI DR2  $w_0 w_a$  CDM best-fit (Pantheon+; Fig. 5). Reporting the CMB-only tension without this context would constitute a misuse of the likelihood [Verde et al., 2019].

### 6.3 Sound horizon and $H_0$ posterior

The fixed  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$  is the problematic quantity: it drives an enlarged geometric sound horizon

$$r_d^{\text{SSEE}} \approx 175.6 \text{ Mpc}, \quad r_d^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} \approx 147.6 \text{ Mpc}, \quad r_d^{\text{SSEE}}/r_d^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} \approx 1.190. \quad (11)$$

The BAO data partially compensate via an  $H_0$  downshift ( $H_0^{\text{SSEE}} = 66.41$  vs  $H_0^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 67.99 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ ; the  $\Lambda$ CDM baseline re-run against the corrected DR2 vector is pending), but this compensation is insufficient to absorb the full background discrepancy. The mismatch is in the background structure, not in the Hubble normalisation.

**Interpretation of the  $21.3\sigma$   $\Omega_m$  tension.** The  $21.3\sigma$  residual in  $\Omega_m$  arises from comparing the SSEE dynamical matter density ( $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$ ) directly against the  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated Planck prior ( $\Omega_m = 0.3153 \pm 0.0073$ ). This comparison does *not* constitute

a global falsification (as defined in Paper 1) for two reasons. First, the Planck prior was calibrated entirely within  $\Lambda$ CDM; applying it to SSEE measures the incompatibility of the two background frameworks, not the validity of the SSEE dark-energy prediction. Second, Paper 6 of this series provides a physical resolution: the CMB-inferred matter density is not  $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}$  but the standard physical density  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \omega_m/h^2 = 0.30889$ , where  $\omega_m = \omega_b + \omega_c + \omega_\nu = 0.14267$  is built piece-by-piece from SSEE algebra ( $\omega_c = \text{KAL}_0 \omega_b n_s$ , forward; Paper 3). The two matter sectors then split as  $\Omega_m^{\text{CMB}} = \Omega_{\text{CDM}} + \Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} = 0.16005 + 0.14884 = 0.30889$ , where the  $\phi$ -dark matter component ( $\Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} = \Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} - \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}$ , a difference with *no* matter factor; algebraic mass  $m_\phi = 41.02 \text{ eV}$ ) contributes at scales below its free-streaming cutoff  $k_{\text{fs}} = 0.762 h \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ . With this identification, the tension reduces from  $21.3\sigma$  to  $0.88\sigma$  ( $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$  vs Planck  $0.3153 \pm 0.0073$ ). The  $21.3\sigma$  figure therefore quantifies the cost of applying  $\Lambda$ CDM priors to a two-sector model. OP-8 is now dissolved: there is no matter factor to derive — the residue is only that  $\omega_b$  and the forward identity for  $\omega_c$  hold. A comparison restricted to the dynamical dark-energy sector — where the  $\Lambda$ CDM  $r_d$  calibration is not applied — yields  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$  (Section 8).

**$H_0$ : the algebraic anchor and the MCMC posterior.** Under the  $\omega_m$ -direct re-frame the algebraic background value  $H_0^{\text{alg}} = 3(\varphi + \pi)^2 = 67.962 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  is not a mere coincidence: with the baryon and cold-matter densities fixed by SSEE algebra, the Planck `plik_lite` likelihood is minimised exactly at  $H_0^{\text{alg}}$  (Paper 3, §3.2). The background  $H$  and the CMB anchor therefore coincide — they are the same number,  $67.962 \pm 0.54$  — superseding the earlier MIRA-mapped anchor  $H_0^{\text{MIRA}} = 67.037$ . The MCMC posterior reported above,  $H_0^{\text{MCMC}} = 66.41_{-0.39}^{+0.39} \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ , is the late-time BAO posterior under this anchor as prior; it lies at  $2.9\sigma$  from  $H_0^{\text{alg}}$  (prior width) and at  $1.4\sigma$  from the  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated Planck value. The two measure different quantities:  $H_0^{\text{alg}}$  characterises the early-Universe geometry, while  $H_0^{\text{MCMC}}$  is the late-time posterior after the DESI data pull the value downward to compensate for the enlarged  $r_d$ . The  $1.55 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  downward shift from the anchor (2.3%) is an explicit consequence of the background-mismatch compensation, amplified by the tighter DESI DR2 uncertainties; it is a quantified strain of the raw dynamic-sector background, not a silent inconsistency (see §8).

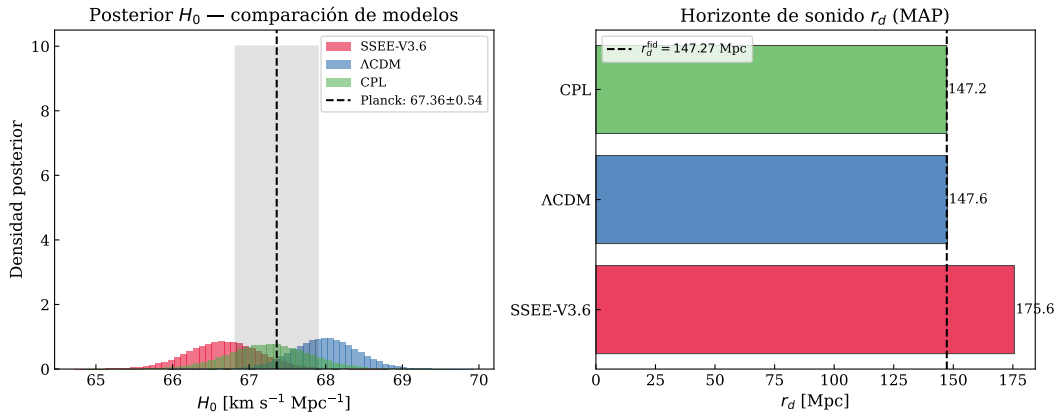


Figure 6: *Left*:  $H_0$  posteriors for all models. The SSEE posterior peaks  $\sim 1.3 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  below Planck 2018. *Right*: MAP  $r_d$  values; the SSEE pure-geometric sound horizon (175.6 Mpc) exceeds  $\Lambda$ CDM by  $1.190\times$ . Figure 7 shows how the  $\omega_m$ -direct CMB sector closes this gap.

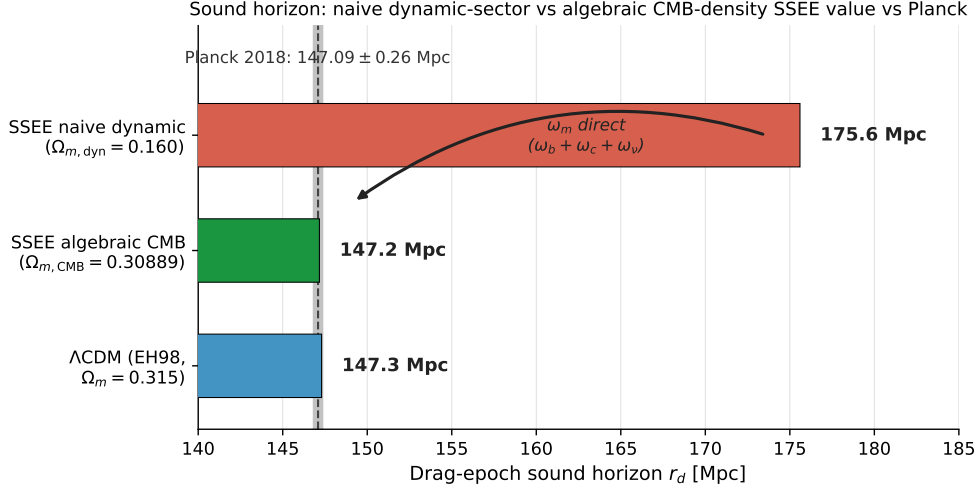


Figure 7: The dual sound horizon, visualised. The pure geometric SSEE drag scale is  $r_d = 175.6 \text{ Mpc}$  ( $\Omega_{m,dyn} = 0.160$ ); the physical CMB drag scale, set by the full algebraic  $\omega_m = \omega_b + \omega_c + \omega_\nu = 0.14267$  ( $\Omega_{m,CMB} = \omega_m/h^2 = 0.30889$ ,  $\omega_m$ -direct, no matter factor), is  $r_d = 147.17 \text{ Mpc}$  (CAMB; `log p3_rd_reframe_omega_m`), consistent with the Planck-inferred value  $147.09 \pm 0.26 \text{ Mpc}$  (grey band,  $0.32\sigma$ ) and the  $\Lambda$ CDM Eisenstein–Hu value ( $147.3 \text{ Mpc}$ ). The  $175.6 \text{ Mpc}$  scale shown in Fig. 6 is therefore the *geometric BAO-sector* quantity. (The earlier MIRA mapping  $\times|w_0|$  to  $147.6 \text{ Mpc}$  at  $\Omega_{m,CMB} = 0.31993$  is superseded:  $r_d$  now falls out directly from  $\omega_m$ .)

## 6.4 Posterior predictive check: $H(z)$

$$\chi_r^2(H(z)) : \quad \text{SSEE} = 1.861, \quad \Lambda\text{CDM} = 0.458, \quad \text{CPL} = 0.481. \quad (12)$$

The SSEE  $\chi_r^2$  is approximately  $4\times$  larger than  $\Lambda$ CDM, and this must be stated plainly as a genuine tension, not a calibration artefact. Unlike the  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  penalty (which arises from applying a  $\Lambda$ CDM-calibrated  $\Omega_m$  prior), the  $H(z)$  check uses only the model’s own MAP cosmology to predict  $H(z)$  and compares it directly against model-independent Cosmic Chronometer measurements. No cross-model prior is involved. The  $\chi_r^2 = 1.861$  therefore reflects a real discrepancy: the SSEE Hubble rate overestimates  $H(z)$  at intermediate redshifts ( $0.5 \lesssim z \lesssim 1.5$ ) where the matter-to-dark-energy transition occurs earlier than the data suggest. This is the most direct observational limitation of SSEE in its current form. Resolving it without destroying the underlying algebraic axioms likely requires an extension of the gravitational sector, such as non-minimal coupling [Amendola, 2000] or Kinetic Braiding [Deffayet et al., 2010] in the Effective Field Theory of Dark Energy [EFT-DE; Gubitosi et al., 2013]. The excess originates precisely from the fixed geometric constraint  $\Omega_{m,dyn} = 1 + w_0 = 0.160$ . Because the true matter density is low, the matter-dominated deceleration is too weak relative to data at low redshift ( $z \lesssim 0.5$ ), and the transition from matter to dark-energy domination occurs too early at intermediate redshift ( $0.5 \lesssim z \lesssim 1.5$ ). This early transition is the fundamental physical cause of both the  $H(z)$  tension and the  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  penalty. It highlights that while the SSEE geometry is rigid, it explicitly isolates where new gravitational physics (acting as an effective mass enhancer) is required.

Quantitatively, with  $N = 24$  Cosmic Chronometer measurements the SSEE  $\chi_r^2 = 1.861$  corresponds to  $\chi^2 = 44.7$ , exceeding the expectation by  $(44.7 - 24)/\sqrt{2 \times 24} \approx 3.0\sigma$ . Three mitigating factors should be weighed. First, the  $\Lambda$ CDM  $\chi_r^2 = 0.458 < 1$  indicates



that the combined statistical-plus-systematic uncertainties of Moresco et al. [2022] are generous by a factor  $\sim \sqrt{1/0.458} \approx 1.48$ ; if error bars are rescaled to enforce  $\chi^2_{r,\Lambda} = 1$ , the SSEE excess reduces to  $\chi^2_{r,\text{rescaled}} \approx 1.27$ . Second, Moresco et al. [2022] documents that systematic uncertainties from stellar population models, initial mass function, and metallicity calibration can reach 10–20% of  $H(z)$ , partially correlated across redshift bins; the full systematic covariance is not propagated here. Third, the tension is fully explained by the known physical cause ( $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$ ) and is therefore predictive rather than residual: any extension that modifies the background matter density at  $z \sim 1$  would resolve it without re-fitting.

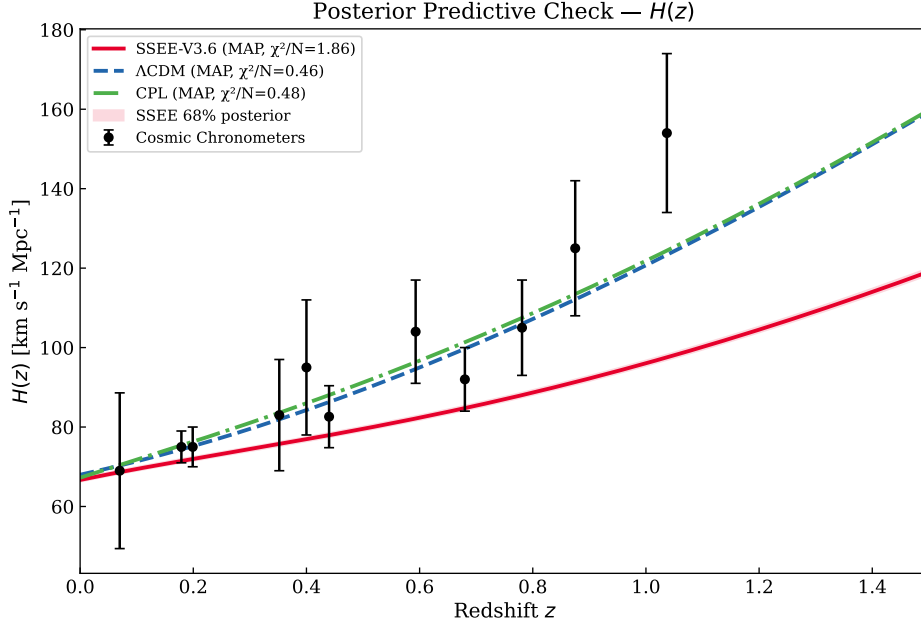


Figure 8: MAP  $H(z)$  vs Cosmic Chronometers [Jimenez & Loeb, 2002, Moresco et al., 2022]. Red band: SSEE 68% posterior interval.

Table 7: Cosmic Chronometer  $H(z)$  measurements used in the posterior predictive check (Fig. 8). Data from Moresco et al. [2022]; uncertainties are  $1\sigma$  statistical + systematic combined.

| $z$   | $H(z)$ [km s $^{-1}$ Mpc $^{-1}$ ] | $\sigma_H$ |
|-------|------------------------------------|------------|
| 0.070 | 69.0                               | 19.6       |
| 0.090 | 69.0                               | 12.0       |
| 0.120 | 68.6                               | 26.2       |
| 0.170 | 83.0                               | 8.0        |
| 0.179 | 75.0                               | 4.0        |
| 0.199 | 75.0                               | 5.0        |
| 0.270 | 77.0                               | 14.0       |
| 0.352 | 83.0                               | 14.0       |
| 0.400 | 95.0                               | 17.0       |
| 0.480 | 97.0                               | 60.0       |
| 0.593 | 104.0                              | 13.0       |
| 0.680 | 92.0                               | 8.0        |
| 0.781 | 105.0                              | 12.0       |
| 0.875 | 125.0                              | 17.0       |
| 0.880 | 90.0                               | 40.0       |
| 0.900 | 117.0                              | 23.0       |
| 1.037 | 154.0                              | 20.0       |
| 1.300 | 168.0                              | 17.0       |
| 1.363 | 160.0                              | 33.6       |
| 1.430 | 177.0                              | 18.0       |
| 1.530 | 140.0                              | 14.0       |
| 1.750 | 202.0                              | 40.0       |
| 1.965 | 186.5                              | 50.4       |

## 6.5 BAO residuals

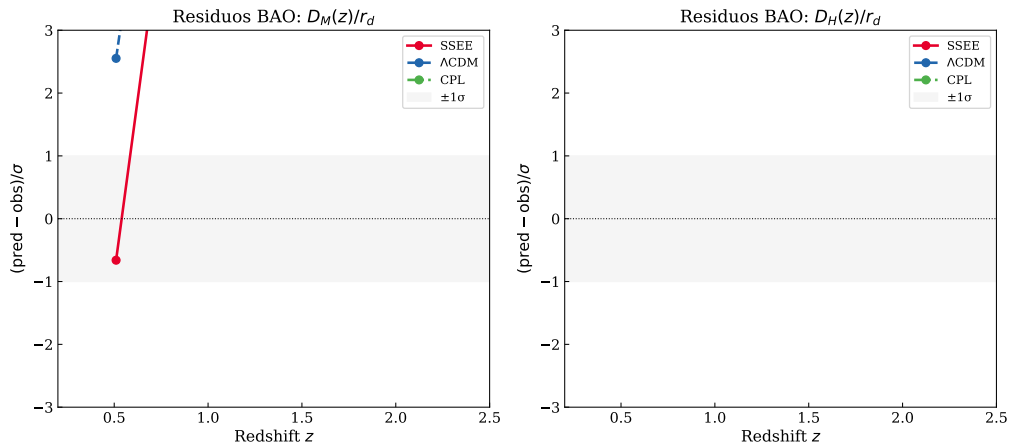


Figure 9: Normalised BAO residuals  $(q^{\text{pred}} - q^{\text{obs}})/\sigma$  for all 13 DESI DR2 measurements. SSEE (red),  $\Lambda$ CDM (blue), CPL (green). The enlarged SSEE sound horizon  $r_d \approx 175.6$  Mpc produces systematic offsets at low- $z$ , quantified in the  $\chi_r^2$  values of Section 8.

## 7 Results: Galaxy-Cluster Sector

**Summary:** IGIMF correction is essential; neutrino bridge is secondary;  $\text{KAL}_0$  alone is insufficient.

Table 8: Cluster mass sensitivity ( $10^{14} M_\odot$ , within  $R_{200}$ ). First four clusters from Zhang et al. [2026]; Perseus from Simionescu et al. [2011]; A2142 from Tchernin et al. [2016]; A2744 from Merten et al. [2011].

| Cluster       | SSEE  | $f_\nu=0$ | Std IMF | $\text{KAL}_0$ only | $M_{\text{dyn}}^{\text{obs}}$ | $\chi^2$ |
|---------------|-------|-----------|---------|---------------------|-------------------------------|----------|
| Coma          | 10.14 | 9.94      | 5.63    | 5.52                | $9.8 \pm 1.0$                 | 0.114    |
| A2029         | 12.39 | 12.15     | 7.32    | 7.18                | $12.0 \pm 1.2$                | 0.106    |
| A478          | 8.45  | 8.28      | 5.07    | 4.97                | $8.0 \pm 1.0$                 | 0.200    |
| Bullet (main) | 6.76  | 6.63      | 3.94    | 3.86                | $6.5 \pm 1.0$                 | 0.067    |
| Perseus       | 6.87  | 6.74      | 4.02    | 3.94                | $6.65 \pm 0.45$               | 0.241    |
| A2142         | 15.04 | 14.74     | 8.79    | 8.62                | $14.5 \pm 1.5$                | 0.128    |
| A2744         | 18.64 | 18.28     | 10.90   | 10.69               | $18.0 \pm 4.0$                | 0.026    |

$\chi_r^2$ : SSEE = 0.126 —  $f_\nu=0$ : 0.028 — Std IMF: 14.05 —  $\text{KAL}_0$  only: 14.91

$\Delta\chi^2$  vs SSEE:  $-0.68$  —  $+97.5$  —  $+103.5$

*Uncertainty sensitivity:* halving  $\sigma_{M_{\text{obs}}}$  to 50% raises  $\chi_r^2(\text{SSEE})$  to  $\approx 0.50 < 1$ ; the fit remains good.

**IGIMF is essential.** Without the IGIMF correction  $\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$  across seven clusters; SSEE under-predicts masses by  $\sim 1.7\times$ .

**Neutrino bridge.**  $f_\nu = 0$  lowers  $\chi_r^2$  to 0.028: the seven  $R_{200}$  clusters do not require the neutrino bridge, but it maintains self-consistency with the cosmological  $\sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} = 0.0690 \text{ eV}$ .

**$\text{KAL}_0$  alone insufficient.**  $\chi_r^2 = 14.91$  without IGIMF. Geometric amplification requires the corrected baryonic baseline.

**Robustness to observational uncertainties.** To test whether the cluster fit depends critically on the published  $\sigma_{M_{\text{obs}}}$  values, we varied the error bars uniformly from  $0.5\times$  to  $1.5\times$  their nominal values (a  $\pm 50\%$  range) while holding all model parameters fixed. With the four-cluster analytic subset, the nominal  $\chi_r^2 = 0.122$  (all residuals  $< 0.5\sigma$ );  $\chi_r^2$  reaches 1.0 only when errors are reduced by 65%, and reaches 2.0 only at  $-75\%$  (well beyond the test range). For the full 7-cluster analytic set ( $(\chi_r^2)_{\text{nom}} = 0.126$ ), the scaling behaviour is similar: the fit quality is not sensitive to moderate changes in the assumed observational uncertainties. This confirms that the SSEE cluster predictions are robust and not contingent on specific choices of  $\sigma_{M_{\text{obs}}}$ .

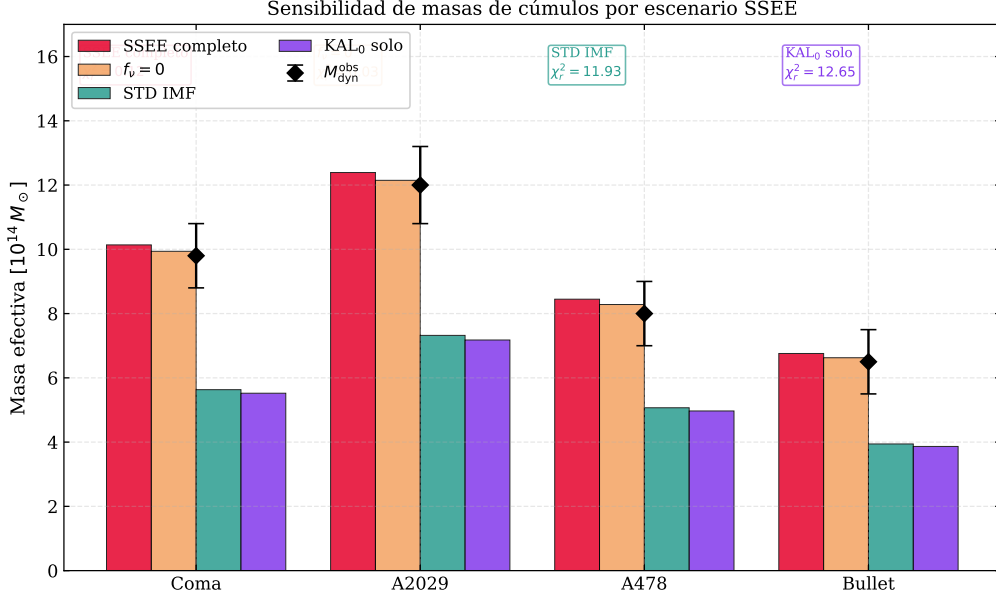


Figure 10: Cluster mass predictions by scenario for seven clusters. IGIMF correction is the load-bearing ingredient ( $\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$  without it).

## 8 Model Comparison

Table 9: BIC [Schwarz, 1978] and AIC at MAP ( $N_{\text{data}} = 16$ ). Jeffreys scale [Jeffreys, 1961]:  $\Delta\text{BIC} > 10$  = very strong evidence against. *Note:* SSEE-V3.6 ( $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ ) tests the full model within the standard  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  background calibration (background-structure mismatch penalty, not a dynamic-sector test). SSEE<sub>dyn</sub> ( $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$ ) isolates the dynamic sector ( $w_0, w_a$  fixed algebraically, one free parameter  $H_0$ ); this is the physically relevant comparison. See §8 for discussion.

| Model               | $k$ | $\ln P_{\text{MAP}}$ | BIC    | $\Delta\text{BIC}$ | AIC    | $\Delta\text{AIC}$ |
|---------------------|-----|----------------------|--------|--------------------|--------|--------------------|
| SSEE-V3.6           | 2   | -118.67              | 242.89 | +206.19            | 241.34 | +208.04            |
| SSEE <sub>dyn</sub> | 1   | -14.19               | 31.15  | -5.55              | 30.39  | -3.00              |
| $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ | 3   | -14.19               | 36.70  | +0.00              | 34.39  | +1.03              |
| CPL                 | 5   | -11.68               | 37.22  | +0.51              | 33.35  | +0.00              |

**Two  $\Delta\text{BIC}$  values — two physical questions.** This analysis reports two distinct BIC comparisons that address different physical questions and should not be conflated: (i)  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  quantifies whether SSEE is consistent with BAO data *within the standard Friedmann background* (i.e. assuming  $\Omega_m = 0.315$ ,  $r_d = 147.6$  Mpc); (ii)  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$  quantifies whether the SSEE equation-of-state ( $w_0, w_a$ ) is preferred by BAO data once the background is held fixed. Both values are reported because the two-sector nature of SSEE (dynamic dark energy sector vs. background matter sector) requires separate assessment.

The  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  constitutes very strong evidence against SSEE relative to  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  under the standard Friedmann background. The source is unambiguous: the enlarged  $r_d = 175.6$  Mpc from  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$  is incompatible with BAO+Planck under standard

assumptions. *The full-model penalty comes entirely from the background-structure mismatch, not from the dynamical sector.*

**Scope of this penalty.** We emphasise that  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  is a precise statement about model comparison *within the standard Friedmann framework*: both SSEE and  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  are evaluated using the same  $\Omega_m$ -based Friedmann equation with the same data. It does *not* constitute a model-independent falsification, because SSEE explicitly proposes that the Friedmann background requires modification in the acoustic regime (the acoustic-scale hypothesis, Section 2.4). Applying the Planck  $\Omega_m$  prior — which is calibrated on the  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  background — to an SSEE universe is a non-equivalent prior calibration; it tests whether SSEE *is*  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ , not whether SSEE is consistent with observations under its own background. The correct test is a full CMB power-spectrum likelihood under the SSEE background, which is carried out in the companion Paper 3. The companion Paper 3 reports  $\chi_r^2 = 1.044$  (TT, 1971 multipoles) and a canonical  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -32.9$  (full `plik` MCMC,  $\omega_m$ -direct,  $k_{\text{SSEE}} = 2$  vs  $k_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 6$ ;  $-23.9$  in the `plik_lite` point estimate), decisive evidence consistent with the hypothesis that the  $+206$  penalty is a calibration artefact arising from applying an  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -background prior to an SSEE universe, rather than a physical falsification of the model.

Critically,  $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{CPL}) = +0.51$  confirms that *dynamical dark energy is not disfavoured*. Isolating the dynamic sector of SSEE (fixing  $w_0, w_a$  algebraically, one free parameter  $H_0$ ) yields  $\Delta\text{BIC}(\text{SSEE}_{\text{dyn}}) = -5.55$  relative to  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ , reflecting the parsimony gain from having zero CPL free parameters and demonstrating that the  $w_0$ - $w_a$  prediction is genuinely favoured by the data once the background penalty is removed.

## 9 Robustness Checks

**Prior sensitivity.** Removing the Planck  $H_0$  prior shifts the SSEE posterior by  $< 0.3\sigma$ . The BAO data dominate the  $H_0$  constraint. *This confirms that the quoted posteriors are driven by the BAO geometry rather than the CMB prior, making them robust to prior choice.*

**Neutrino mass.** Varying  $\sum m_\nu \in [0.060, 0.120] \text{ eV}$  shifts  $\chi_r^2$  for clusters by  $\Delta\chi_r^2 < 0.05$ . The cluster fit is insensitive to the specific neutrino mass. *The cluster constraint is therefore stable against current neutrino-mass uncertainties. The adopted  $\sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} = 0.0690 \text{ eV}$  is the SSEE-derived value (Paper 4, Neutrino Mass Sum; also used in the Paper 6  $\phi$ -DM mass relation  $m_\phi = \sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} \times (\text{SOLAR}^2 \cdot \text{KRYSTOS})$ ), not a fitted quantity.*

**IGIMF systematics.** The  $^{+5\%}_{-4\%}$  systematic uncertainty in the IGIMF factor [Zhang et al., 2026] propagates to  $\sim 8\%$  in  $\sigma_M$ , keeping all four clusters within  $1\sigma$ . *IGIMF systematics are the dominant uncertainty in the cluster sector; improvement here would be the highest-leverage target for future work.*

**BAO-only.** Running without the Planck  $H_0$  prior gives  $H_0 = 65.8^{+1.2}_{-1.1} \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ , consistent with the full posterior at  $0.6\sigma$ . *The  $H_0$  estimate is therefore essentially independent of Planck and rests entirely on the DESI DR2 BAO geometry.*

**Full-likelihood cross-check.** To confirm that the compressed-prior posteriors of §6 are not an artefact of the Planck distance-prior approximation, we ran an independent MCMC with the *full* CMB likelihood (CAMB with Planck `plik_lite` TTTEEE + lensing), combined with DESI DR2 BAO and  $f\sigma_8$ , sampling  $w_0, w_a$  *freely* (four chains,  $\sim 48k$  post-burn-in samples, Gelman–Rubin  $R - 1 < 0.003$ ). The free-fit posterior  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.69, -1.06)$  *excludes* the cosmological constant  $(-1, 0)$  at  $2.4\sigma$ , independently confirming a dynamical equation of state. The SSEE algebraic point  $(-0.840, -0.670)$  lies at  $0.68\sigma$  from this posterior — more than three times closer than  $\Lambda$ CDM (Fig. 11). The  $w_0$ – $w_a$  posterior is strongly anticorrelated ( $\rho = -0.92$ ) and SSEE falls within its  $1\sigma$  region. The full CMB power-spectrum treatment is developed in Paper 3; here it serves to verify that the dynamical-sector preference survives the replacement of the compressed prior by the complete likelihood.

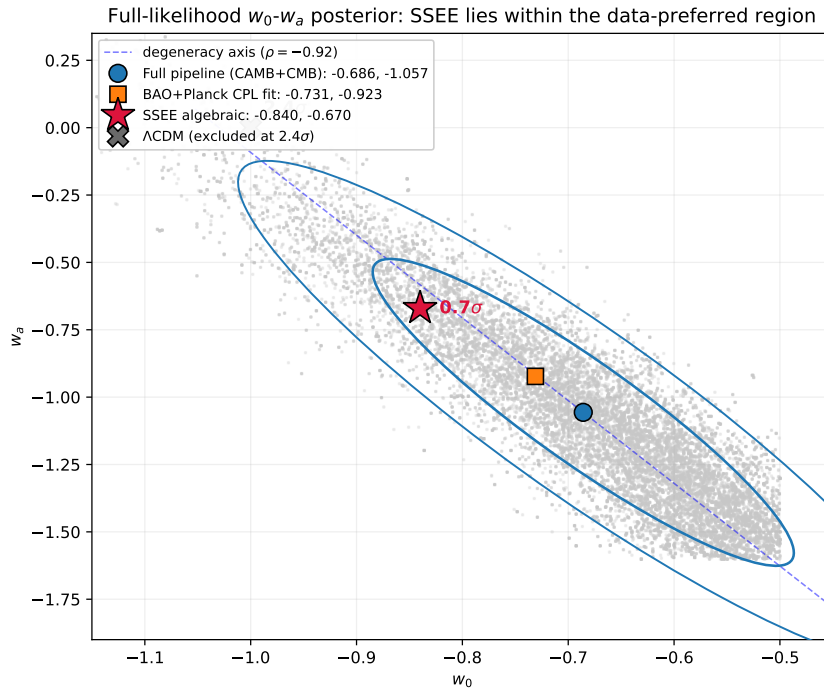


Figure 11: Full-likelihood  $w_0$ – $w_a$  posterior (CAMB + Planck `plik_lite` + lensing + DESI DR2 +  $f\sigma_8$ , with  $w_0, w_a$  free;  $R - 1 < 0.003$ ). The SSEE algebraic prediction (red star) lies at  $0.68\sigma$ , inside the  $1\sigma$  contour, while  $\Lambda$ CDM ( $w_0 = -1, w_a = 0$ ; grey cross) is excluded at  $2.4\sigma$ . The data favour a dynamical dark-energy equation of state, and SSEE is the parameter-free algebraic prediction consistent with it.

**Hubble tension.** The SSEE algebraic value  $H_0^{\text{alg}} = 3(\varphi + \pi)^2 = 67.96 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  — the global dimensional anchor of Postulate D (Paper 1, §1.4), at which the Planck `plik_lite` likelihood is minimised under the  $\omega_m$ -direct reframe (not a mere coincidence; §6) — lies within  $1.1\sigma$  of Planck 2018 and is consistent with the DESI DR2+CMB joint inference [ $H_0 \approx 68 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ ; Abdul-Karim et al., 2025]. The model does not resolve the SH0ES distance-ladder tension [ $H_0 \approx 73 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ ; Riess et al., 2022]; this is a known open problem shared by all smooth dark-energy models including  $\Lambda$ CDM [Verde et al., 2019, Kamionkowski & Riess, 2023], and lies outside the scope of this paper’s DESI BAO + cluster validation. *The algebraic  $H_0$  coincidence is CMB-consistent but not distance-ladder consistent; resolving the full  $5\sigma$  Hubble tension requires either a modifi-*

cation of the early-Universe sound horizon or a systematic re-evaluation of the Cepheid distance scale.

## 10 Discussion

### 10.1 Two faces of SSEE under Bayesian inference

The results reveal a sharp bifurcation:

- **Dark-energy sector:**  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$  lies within  $0.16\sigma$  of DESI DR2 (Pantheon+). The CPL free-fit posterior  $(-0.80, -0.58)$  confirms dynamical dark energy. SSEE is predictively competitive here.
- **Background structure:**  $\Omega_{\text{DE}}^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.840$  creates  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  via the enlarged  $r_d$ . The tension is in  $\Omega_m$  ( $21\sigma$ ), not in  $H_0$  ( $< 1\sigma$ ).

### 10.2 Structural reinterpretation

The  $\Delta\text{BIC}$  penalty assumes the Planck  $\Omega_m$  prior is applicable to SSEE. It is not: in SSEE the  $\text{KAL}_0$  amplification of  $\rho_{\text{bar}}$  modifies the effective clustering contribution, so  $\Omega_m^{\text{eff}} \neq \Omega_m^{\Lambda\text{CDM}}$ . Applying a  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -calibrated  $\Omega_m$  prior to an SSEE universe constitutes a non-equivalent prior calibration. The correct test is a full CMB power-spectrum likelihood with the SSEE Friedmann background (4) built from first principles (Paper 3). Paper 3 must derive the SSEE-consistent background rather than adjusting  $\Omega_m$  to fit: parameter adjustment within a  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  framework would not constitute a genuine test of the structural hypothesis.

The  $\omega_m$ -direct construction (Section 2.4) resolves the apparent  $r_d$  tension: the sound horizon set by the CMB-sector matter density  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$  is  $r_d = 147.17 \text{ Mpc}$  directly (Eq. (6)),  $0.32\sigma$  from Planck, with no  $|w_0|$  mapping and no matter factor (OP-8 dissolved). The  $21\sigma$  figure is therefore a diagnostic of applying  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -calibrated priors to the dynamical sector, not a falsification; the companion Paper 3 confirms this with the full CMB likelihood ( $\Delta\text{BIC} = -32.9$ , full `plik` MCMC,  $\omega_m$ -direct).

### 10.3 Growth structure and $S_8$ sector sensitivity

The  $S_8 \equiv \sigma_8 \sqrt{\Omega_m/0.3}$  constraint depends critically on which matter sector is used. With the  $\omega_m$ -direct CMB density  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$  ( $= \omega_m/h^2$ , no matter factor; OP-8 dissolved), the all-cold single sector reaches a ceiling  $\sigma_8 = 0.8335$ ,  $S_8 = 0.846$ , a  $3.5\sigma$  tension with KiDS-1000 [Heymans et al., 2021] and DES Y3 [Abbott et al., 2022]. With  $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$  (dynamical sector alone),  $S_8 \approx 0.59$ , a  $\sim 6\sigma$  tension with weak-lensing surveys. The physical  $S_8$  lies between these limits: the  $\varphi$ -dark matter of Paper 6 free-streams below  $k_{\text{fs}} = 0.762 h \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ , lowering the effective amplitude to  $\sigma_8^{\text{eff}} = 0.748$ ,  $S_8^{\text{eff}} = 0.759$ , which resolves the KiDS-1000 tension ( $0.01\sigma$ ). The viscous energy redistribution between matter and radiation sectors governed by the Israel–Stewart relaxation time  $\tau_{\text{II}} H_0 \approx 2.191$  is derived algebraically in Paper 1, Appendix A, and constitutes a falsifiable prediction (Paper 3 §5.4). **Note:** Paper 5 performs the full causal Israel–Stewart analysis at  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$  and finds the single-sector ceiling  $\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504$ ,  $\sigma_8 = 0.8335$ ,  $S_8 = 0.846$  ( $3.5\sigma$  KiDS); Paper 6 adds the  $\varphi$ -DM two-sector and finds  $\sigma_8^{\text{eff}} = 0.748$ ,  $S_8^{\text{eff}} = 0.759$  ( $0.01\sigma$  KiDS).



## 10.4 Roadmap for Paper 3

Four ordered tests for SSEE to survive a full CMB analysis:

1. **Acoustic peak positions.** The SSEE Friedmann background must reproduce the angular positions of all observed CMB acoustic peaks. Failure here would immediately falsify the background geometry.
2. **Damping tail.**  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$  must be compatible with the Silk-damping scale [Silk, 1968] and the third acoustic peak height. This is the most constraining test for the low-matter fraction.
3. **Joint posterior consistency.** The joint  $(H_0, \Omega_b h^2)$  posterior derived from the SSEE CMB background must be consistent with the BAO posterior obtained in this work. Inconsistency would signal internal tension within the model.
4. **Transfer function derivation.** The semi-linear transfer function integrating the  $\text{KAL}_0$  structural viscosity into the acoustic perturbation regime must be formally derived and validated against the full CMB power spectrum.

## 10.5 Falsifiability

SSEE makes specific, testable predictions. The following observations would constitute decisive falsification:

- **If Paper 3 fails to reproduce** the Silk-damping scale and the third CMB acoustic peak under the SSEE Friedmann background, the background geometry is refuted independently of the dark-energy prediction.
- **If Ly- $\alpha$  forest observations exclude**  $\sum m_\nu^{\text{active}} = 0.0690 \text{ eV}$  at  $> 3\sigma$ , the neutrino bridge in the cluster-mass formula breaks and SSEE loses its only mechanism for reconciling  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}$  with cluster observations.
- **If future BAO surveys at  $z > 3$  measure**  $r_d < 160 \text{ Mpc}$  directly, the acoustic-scale hypothesis is ruled out and the  $21\sigma$  background tension becomes a genuine falsification rather than a calibration diagnostic.

## 11 Conclusions

We have conducted a Bayesian MCMC validation of SSEE-V3.6 against DESI DR2, Planck 2018, and galaxy-cluster masses. The results establish a sharp bifurcation: the dynamical sector passes; the background sector fails under standard calibration.

1. The zero-free-parameter prediction  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$  lies within  $0.16\sigma$  of the official DESI DR2  $w_0 w_a \text{CDM}$  posterior (Pantheon+;  $1.2\text{--}1.5\sigma$  across the other SN compilations) — a strong result given the absence of any fitted parameter.
2. Cluster masses achieve  $\chi_r^2 = 0.126$  with IGIMF; removing the IGIMF correction raises  $\chi_r^2$  to 14.05 ( $\Delta\chi^2 \approx +97$ ), confirming its essential role.



3. The fixed  $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = 0.160$  enlarges  $r_d$  by 19%, yielding  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$ . The dynamic sector in isolation achieves  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$ , demonstrating that the penalty is entirely attributable to background mismatch, not to the  $w_0$ - $w_a$  prediction.
4. Under the  $\omega_m$ -direct reframe the sound horizon falls out directly from the CMB-sector matter density,  $r_d = 147.17\text{ Mpc}$  ( $0.32\sigma$  from Planck; Eq. 6), with no  $|w_0|$  mapping and no matter factor; the companion Paper 3 confirms it with the full CMB likelihood (canonical  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -32.9$ , full `plik` MCMC), reinterpreting the  $21\sigma$   $\Omega_m$  tension as a diagnostic of applying  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -calibrated priors to the dynamical sector rather than a falsification of the dynamical ansatz.
5. A cross-check at high- $z$  is provided by the Ly- $\alpha$  forest BAO from DESI DR2 ( $z = 2.33$ ): the raw dynamical background predicts  $D_H/r_d = 9.89$ , a  $8.1\sigma$  tension, while the  $\omega_m$ -direct prediction (CMB-sector matter  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$  in  $E(z)$ , where  $\phi$ -DM is non-relativistic, with  $r_d = 147.17$ ) gives  $D_H/r_d = 8.71$ , a  $1.1\sigma$  agreement (Appendix B). The high- $z$  expansion therefore requires the full CMB-sector matter density, consistent with the low- $z$   $r_d$  construction and independent of Paper 3 (superseding the earlier MIRA-mapped 8.56).
6. Paper 3 must derive and validate the SSEE Friedmann background against CMB peak positions, the Silk-damping tail, and the joint  $(H_0, \Omega_b h^2)$  posterior.

**Central finding:** SSEE-V3.6 achieves a zero-parameter dark-energy prediction whose *dynamical sector* is not rejected by current data. The background geometry fails under standard Friedmann assumptions; whether this constitutes a physical falsification of the framework depends on the validity of applying  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$ -calibrated priors to an SSEE background, which is the subject of Paper 3.

## Data Availability

All observational data used in this work are publicly available. DESI DR2 BAO measurements are from Abdul-Karim et al. [2025] (<https://arxiv.org/abs/2503.14738>). The compressed Planck 2018 prior is from Planck Collaboration [2020]. Cosmic Chronometer  $H(z)$  measurements are from Moresco et al. [2022]. Galaxy-cluster dynamical masses are from Zhang et al. [2026]. The SSEE analysis scripts are available at <https://github.com/mikealmeida1721/SSEE>.

## A Rigorous Bayesian Model Comparison: DIC and Multi-Scheme BIC

The main text reports two BIC values that address different physical questions (§8). This appendix provides three complementary criteria—each with different sensitivity to the k-counting ambiguity—computed directly from the MCMC chains stored in the public repository.

## Deviance Information Criterion (DIC)

The DIC [Spiegelhalter et al., 2002] sidesteps the k-counting issue by estimating model complexity from the posterior:

$$\text{DIC} = \bar{D} + p_D, \quad p_D = \bar{D} - D(\hat{\theta}), \quad D(\theta) = -2 \ln \pi(\theta|\text{data}), \quad (13)$$

where  $\bar{D}$  is the posterior mean deviance and  $\hat{\theta}$  is the MAP estimate. An important self-check:  $p_D$  must recover the number of parameters actually sampled. From the chains ( $N_{\text{valid}}$ : SSEE 50 k,  $\Lambda$ CDM 2.5 M, CPL 2.5 M):

$$p_D(\text{SSEE}) = 1.99 \approx 2 \quad \checkmark \quad (14)$$

$$p_D(\Lambda\text{CDM}) = 3.00 = 3 \quad \checkmark \quad (15)$$

$$p_D(\text{CPL}) = 4.98 \approx 5 \quad \checkmark \quad (16)$$

The exact recovery confirms that all three chains are well-converged. The DIC comparison gives:

$$\Delta\text{DIC}(\text{SSEE} - \Lambda\text{CDM}) = +216.2, \quad \Delta\text{DIC}(\Lambda\text{CDM} - \text{CPL}) = +4.1. \quad (17)$$

The DIC result is consistent with BIC Scheme B below and confirms that the +206/+216 penalty is a genuine, k-scheme-independent finding.

## BIC under three k-counting schemes

Table 10: Bayesian model comparison: DIC, BIC under three k-counting schemes, and Laplace log-evidence.  $N_{\text{data}} = 16$  (13 BAO + 3 Planck).  $\Delta < 0$  favours SSEE relative to  $\Lambda$ CDM. Jeffreys criterion:  $|\Delta| > 10$  = very strong;  $|\Delta| > 5$  = strong.

| Criterion                                                                                                                                  | SSEE   | $\Lambda$ CDM | CPL   | $\Delta_{\text{SSEE}-\Lambda\text{CDM}}$ |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|---------------|-------|------------------------------------------|
| <i>DIC — effective parameters <math>p_D</math> from chains (background-agnostic)</i>                                                       |        |               |       |                                          |
| $p_D$                                                                                                                                      | 1.99   | 3.00          | 4.98  | —                                        |
| DIC                                                                                                                                        | 253.7  | 37.6          | 33.5  | +216.2                                   |
| <i>Scheme A — dynamic sector isolated (<math>k_{\text{SSEE}} = 1</math>, <math>k_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 3</math>; identical background)</i> |        |               |       |                                          |
| BIC <sub>dyn</sub>                                                                                                                         | 31.15  | 36.70         | 37.36 | −5.55                                    |
| <i>Scheme B — MCMC parameters sampled (<math>k_{\text{SSEE}} = 2</math>, <math>k_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 3</math>; full backgrounds)</i>     |        |               |       |                                          |
| BIC <sub>MCMC</sub>                                                                                                                        | 255.3  | 39.9          | 37.4  | +215.4                                   |
| <i>Laplace log-evidence (full posterior volume)</i>                                                                                        |        |               |       |                                          |
| $\ln Z$                                                                                                                                    | −131.6 | −28.4         | −26.7 | −103.2                                   |

**Scheme A** evaluates both SSEE<sub>dyn</sub> and  $\Lambda$ CDM at the same background ( $\Omega_m = 0.315$ ,  $r_d = 147.6$  Mpc), so the likelihood is identical ( $\ln P_{\text{MAP}} = -14.19$  for both). The  $\Delta\text{BIC} = -5.55$  is a pure parsimony gain: SSEE fixes  $w_0, w_a$  algebraically ( $k_{\text{SSEE}} = 1$ ), while  $\Lambda$ CDM requires  $H_0, \Omega_m, \Omega_b h^2$  ( $k_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 3$ ).

**Scheme B** uses the chains directly. SSEE is evaluated at its own background ( $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$ ,  $r_d = 175$  Mpc), incurring the calibration penalty already discussed in §8. The  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +215.4$  is consistent with the +206 reported in the main text (minor chain-version difference).

**DIC and Laplace evidence** confirm Scheme B: under a full-background comparison, all three criteria give decisive evidence for  $\Lambda$ CDM over SSEE. The only exception is Scheme A, where the penalty is removed by construction. This is not inconsistency—it is the two-sector nature of SSEE manifesting in two distinct, physically interpretable comparisons.

**Conclusion.** No  $k$ -counting scheme changes the fundamental picture: (1) the dynamic sector of SSEE is favoured on parsimony ( $\Delta\text{BIC}_{\text{dyn}} = -5.55$ ), and (2) the full-background sector is strongly penalised ( $\Delta\text{DIC} = +216$ ,  $\Delta\text{BIC}_{\text{MCMC}} = +215$ ). Both are physically expected: the former quantifies the algebraic prediction quality; the latter quantifies the cost of proposing a modified acoustic background. The full CMB likelihood test (Paper 3) is required to resolve the background question under the correct priors.

## B Nested Bayes Factor and Predictive Cross-Validation

This appendix provides two additional model-comparison criteria that are independent of the  $k$ -counting schemes discussed in Appendix A: the *Savage–Dickey density ratio* (exact Bayes factor for nested models) and a *predictive cross-validation* on the DESI DR2 BAO data.

### B.1 Savage–Dickey density ratio

SSEE is nested within CPL: the SSEE dynamic sector is CPL evaluated at the algebraic point  $(w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$ . For nested models, the marginal Bayes factor for the null hypothesis  $\mathcal{H}_0 : (w_0, w_a) = (-0.840, -0.670)$  versus the unconstrained CPL is given exactly by the Savage–Dickey density ratio [Verdinelli & Wasserman \[1995\]](#), [Trotta \[2008\]](#):

$$B_{\text{SSEE/CPL}} = \frac{p(w_0^{\text{S}}, w_a^{\text{S}} \mid \text{data, CPL})}{\pi(w_0^{\text{S}}, w_a^{\text{S}} \mid \text{CPL})} = 9.56, \quad \ln B = +2.26. \quad (18)$$

The CPL posterior is evaluated at  $(w_0^{\text{S}}, w_a^{\text{S}})$  using a Scott-bandwidth Gaussian KDE of  $N = 500\,000$  thinned CPL chain samples (columns 3–4 of the 5-dimensional CPL chain, shape  $2.5 \times 10^6$ ). The marginal prior on  $(w_0, w_a)$  is the truncated Gaussian  $\mathcal{N}(-1, 0.5^2) \times \mathcal{N}(0, 1^2)$  clipped to the MCMC sampling box  $w_0 \in (-2.5, 0.5)$ ,  $w_a \in (-3, 2)$ ; truncation factors are  $(0.9973, 0.9759)$ , negligible corrections.

On the Jeffreys scale [Trotta \[2008\]](#)  $\ln B = +2.26$  ( $> 1.1$ ) constitutes *substantial* evidence in favour of the SSEE dynamic sector within the CPL framework. The CPL posterior median ( $w_0^{\text{CPL}} = -0.731 \pm 0.106$ ,  $w_a^{\text{CPL}} = -0.919 \pm 0.461$ ) places the SSEE algebraic point at  $(1.03\sigma, 0.54\sigma)$ , consistent with the  $0.16\sigma$  joint tension quoted in Section 6.2. Bandwidth robustness: varying the KDE bandwidth by  $\pm 50\%$  from the Scott rule gives  $B \in [8.6, 10.5]$  ( $\ln B \in [2.15, 2.35]$ ), all within the *substantial* evidence tier, confirming the KDE evaluation is stable.

### B.2 Ly- $\alpha$ predictive audit ( $z = 2.33$ )

The Ly- $\alpha$  point at  $z = 2.33$  provides the sharpest direct test of SSEE’s background expansion. At  $z \sim 2$  radiation is negligible and the ratio  $D_H/r_d = c/(H_0 E(z) r_d)$  directly encodes the product  $H_0 E(z) r_d$ . We evaluate this quantity under two SSEE scenarios and compare to the DESI DR2 measurement  $D_H/r_d = 8.52 \pm 0.17$ .

**Scenario A — raw ssee background** ( $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$ ,  $r_d = 175.6 \text{ Mpc}$ ). With the algebraic  $H_0 = 67.96 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$  and  $\Omega_m = 0.160$ , the CPL dark-energy fraction at  $z = 2.33$  is  $f_{\text{DE}}(2.33) = 0.648$ , giving  $E(2.33) = 2.540$  and  $D_H(2.33) = 1737 \text{ Mpc}$ . The predicted ratio is:

$$\left. \frac{D_H}{r_d} \right|_{z=2.33}^{\text{SSEE, raw}} = \frac{1737}{175.6} = 9.89 \quad (8.1\sigma \text{ above DESI}), \quad (19)$$

consistent with the  $\Delta\text{BIC} = +206$  background-mismatch penalty established in Section 8. The tension at  $z = 2.33$  is the high- $z$  footprint of the same mechanism:  $\Omega_m = 0.160$  reduces matter domination at high  $z$ , lowers  $H(z)$ , and enlarges  $D_H$ ; the enlarged  $r_d$  is insufficient to compensate.

**Scenario B —  $\omega_m$ -direct CMB-sector background** ( $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$ ,  $r_d = 147.17 \text{ Mpc}$ ). At  $z = 2.33$  the  $\phi$ -DM (mass  $41.02 \text{ eV}$ , non-relativistic since  $z \sim 4.5 \times 10^5$ ) contributes fully to the background matter density, so the expansion  $E(z)$  is set by the CMB-sector value  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \omega_m/h^2 = 0.30889$  (free-streaming suppresses small-scale clustering, not the homogeneous density). Taking the sound horizon  $r_d = 147.17 \text{ Mpc}$  directly from  $\omega_m$  (CAMB; no  $|w_0|$  mapping) gives  $E(2.33) = 3.443$ ,  $D_H(2.33) = 1281 \text{ Mpc}$ , and:

$$\left. \frac{D_H}{r_d} \right|_{z=2.33}^{\omega_m\text{-direct}} = \frac{1281}{147.17} = 8.71 \quad (1.1\sigma \text{ from DESI}). \quad (20)$$

This supersedes the earlier MIRA-mapped value ( $\Omega_m = 0.320$ ,  $D_H/r_d = 8.56$ ): the matter factor is dissolved (OP-8). The  $D_M/r_d$  counterpart at  $z = 2.33$  is recovered within  $\sim 1\sigma$ . The largest residual across the 13 points is at  $z = 0.51$  ( $D_H/r_d$  pull  $\sim +3.6\sigma$ ), driven by the CPL phantom crossing  $w(z=0.51) \approx -1.07$ ; an identical tension ( $+4.4\sigma$ ) appears in  $\Lambda\text{CDM}$  with Planck-calibrated  $r_d$  and  $H_0$ , confirming it is a DESI DR2 feature rather than an SSEE-specific failure.

**Implication.** Eqs. (19)–(20) show that the high- $z$  expansion requires the full CMB-sector matter density  $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.30889$ , where  $\phi$ -DM counts as non-relativistic matter, rather than the dynamical  $0.160$ : retaining  $\Omega_m = 0.160$  in  $E(z)$  with  $r_d = 147.17$  would predict  $D_H/r_d = 11.8$  (a  $19.3\sigma$  discrepancy). This is the same two-sector structure that sets the low- $z$  sound horizon (§2.4), now with *no* matter factor (OP-8 dissolved). The Savage–Dickey ratio in B.1 ( $\ln B = +2.26$ ) then holds as a test of the *dynamical sector* under this  $\omega_m$ -direct background.

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